

LIMINAL BECOMINGS: THE PROFESSIONALIZATION PROJECT OF PEER SUPPORT WORKERS

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ABSTRACT

Peer support workers are increasingly recognized for their unique role in mental health care, and hired as paid providers. Yet, despite decades of efforts, their professional status remains precarious. Based on an extensive longitudinal case study (2015–2024), we analyze the struggle of peer support workers to carve out a work jurisdiction within the professional sector of Quebec’s mental health system. Using liminality theory, we investigate how the role of peer support workers is creating ambiguity and tensions that might both enable and harm their project. We discuss the theoretical implications of our findings for studies of liminality and professionalization.

INTRODUCTION

Professionalization projects involve occupational groups organizing to construct a cultural mandate – “the socially conferred right to perform a given set of tasks” (Nelsen & Barley, 1997: 619). This implies gaining support from stakeholders including regulators, managers, established professions, and clients (Fayard et al., 2017; Muzio et al., 2020; Nigam & Dokko, 2019). Professions base their mandate on a claim to exclusive expertise to address a particular type of social problem, typically acquired through credentialed institutional education (Huisin, 2022). Yet so far, few studies have explored how professionalization projects might play out for occupational groups that have been located at the nexus of community and professional sectors over extended periods of time, and whose historical reason for existence is grounded in community service more than credentialed expertise. Yet, this phenomenon has important implications for those who pursue such projects, and for stakeholders in the professional domains where these projects unfold.

In this paper, we study the historical development of peer support work in mental health care, a striking example of professionalization project that is stuck in-between the community and professional sectors. We track the construction of a cultural mandate and work jurisdiction over time by this occupational group claiming primary non-credentialed forms of knowledge. Based on longitudinal ethnographic data, we map the emergence and professionalization of peer

support work in the Canadian province of Quebec from 1961 to 2024, with a primary focus on the period of professionalization (2005-2024), seeking to address this research question: *How does liminality shape the pursuit of professionalization projects over time?*

THEORETICAL BACKGROUND

The theoretical background unfolds in two parts. First, we synthesize the key conditions for the existence of a profession. And second, we review the management literature on liminality in the workplace which we use as a sensitizing concept for this study.

Professionalization projects

The organizational literature on professions foregrounds several conditions for a profession to exist: a base of exclusive knowledge, an association of practitioners, a cultural mandate, and a work jurisdiction (Anteby et al., 2016; Langley et al., 2019; Nigam & Dokko, 2019). First, the members of an occupation must monopolize an *exclusive knowledge base*—often codified through specialized training and credentials—that outsiders cannot easily imitate. Second, they need a robust *professional association* to certify members, enforce ethics, and sanction deviance, thereby signalling self-regulation to the state and the public. Third, they must secure a *cultural mandate*: a widely shared belief that the occupation provides an indispensable public good and therefore deserves deference (Abbott, 1988; Freidson, 1986). Finally, they require a legally protected *work jurisdiction* that reserves particular tasks and titles for licensed members and penalizes encroachment (Muzio et al., 2020). These pillars are mutually reinforcing—credentials feed association power; associations lobby for legal shelter; legal shelter stabilizes exclusive knowledge—but they are also mutually vulnerable. If expertise is contested, if association splinters, or if policymakers withdraw support, the occupation may slip into regulatory limbo, lacking both market closure and moral authority.

Occupational liminality

Organization scholars have borrowed the concept of liminality from anthropology to describe the “betwixt-and-between” zones where old identities have been shed but new ones are not yet secured (Van Gennep, 1909; Turner, 1969). Drawing on liminality theory, we identified the themes of *communitas*, in-betweenness, and transition as especially relevant to answer our research question. *Communitas* refers to the horizontal solidarity, fostering experimentation and critique, that flourishes between peers undergoing a transformation in social role, typically towards higher status (Howard-Grenville et al., 2011; Johnson et al., 2010). In-betweenness captures the structural positioning of actors who straddle multiple social worlds, gaining brokerage advantages yet suffering identity strain (Czarniawska & Mazza, 2003; Ryan, 2019). Transition refers to the passage toward incorporation in a new societal status; but research shows such passages can freeze into perpetual liminality, leaving groups in chronic uncertainty (Budtz-Jørgensen et al., 2019; Ybema et al., 2011). Thus, while liminality opens up new possibilities, it also involves ambiguity for members of occupations embodying hybrid roles and seeking professional status.

Drawing on the concepts reviewed in this section, we analyze the case of peer support workers in Quebec to show how liminality shaped the pursuit of their professionalization project

over recent decades, and we discuss the implications of this project for those who pursue it, and for other stakeholders. In the discussion, we intend to explore the transferability of our findings to occupational groups pursuing professionalization projects in other professional domains.

METHODS

We conducted a qualitative longitudinal study in the Canadian province of Quebec spanning between 2015 and 2024, tracking the efforts of peer support workers to construct a mandate and establish work jurisdiction in the professional sector of mental health care. Data collection includes 84 detailed fieldwork notes from participant observation involving peer support workers, 50 in-depth interviews with peer support workers and other key actors occupying various institutional positions related to peer support workers entering the professional sector, 43 memos covering full meetings of the Montreal community of practice of peer support workers, as well as 92 publicly available and working documents deemed relevant to understand the historical events, and also the more recent events in which the lead author participated. In parallel with this study, the lead author, himself a peer support worker certified as part of the 2016 Peer Network cohort (covered in participant observation notes), has been until recently an active member of the provincial peer support community. As a result, this study also benefits from insights gained through countless hours of informal community participation.

Data analysis occurred in two main steps. In the first step, we focused on developing a detailed historical timeline of events leading to the entry of peer support workers in Quebec's professional sector of mental health care. To map the process longitudinally, we constructed a visual representation of this timeline emphasizing the relational dynamics between actors related to the professional sector and/or to the service users' movement. In the second step, we constructed a historical timeline to identify the analytical significance of key events to understand the dynamics involved in the pursuit the professional project of peer support workers. Following a temporal bracketing strategy (Langley, 1999), we divided the historical timeline into four discrete phases, which we labeled to emphasize the key dynamics playing out over time. Analysis of the period of emergence of peer support work, represented by Phases 1 and 2 (1961 – 2004), is based on published research, historical documents, and interviews with key actors who have participated in or are acquainted with the events. Analysis of the period of professionalization of peer support work, represented by Phases 3 and 4 (2005 – 2024) is based on interviews with direct participants in the events, participant observation notes, as well as published and working documents.

FINDINGS

Our temporal bracketing reveals two periods divided into four relatively distinct phases related to the pursuit of peer support workers' professional project.

Period of emergence of peer support work (1961–2004)

Phase 1: Coming together of communitas (1961–1986). The spark was Jean-Charles Pagé's searing memoir "The Mad are Crying for Help!" (1961), which exposed asylum abuses and was widely covered in the francophone press. Former patients, artists, and church activists responded by opening drop-in centres and self-help "mutual-aid houses" across Montréal and Québec City. In those liminal spaces, ex-patients ceased to be objects of treatment and recast

themselves as co-learners, exchanging experiential wisdom outside psychiatric authority. The Bédard Commission report (1962) acknowledged their testimony, legitimising the movement's critique and galvanising a *communitas* of lived-experience advocates. Lacking funding, credentials, or titles, this *communitas* nonetheless forged the first element of a professional mandate: the claim to exclusive knowledge of recovery.

Phase 2: Formation of an in-between zone (1987–2004). Policy discourse pivoted when the Harnois Report (1987) reframed mental-health strategy from custodial care to psychosocial rehabilitation, explicitly calling for partnerships with service-user groups. Three reformist psychiatrists and two user leaders founded the “Québec Association for Psychosocial Rehabilitation” (Rehab). Rehab's magazine *Le Partenaire* and a large annual symposium functioned as a liminal bridge: community activists, clinicians, and bureaucrats met on equal footing, and the term “peer supporter” entered official vocabulary. By 2004, peer support workers enjoyed a growing cultural mandate yet still lacked recognized credentials, a practitioner association, or a legal jurisdiction.

Period of professionalization of peer support work (2005–2024)

Phase 3: Precarious professional transition (2005–2014). The Ministry's Action Plan (2005) ordered ACT teams to employ peer support workers in 30 % of posts, but rejected calls for a dedicated title, arguing that “flexibility” was preferable. Hospitals therefore signed service-loan contracts: a community NGO hired the peer support workers, invoicing the hospital at cost + 15 % administration. Rehab and the user-run Advocates launched the Peer Network, a two-week intensive certificate endorsed (but not credited) by Université Laval—thereby satisfying the “exclusive knowledge” requirement. Yet peer support workers remained outsiders-within: they drew salaries but were invisible to HR systems and dependent on annual grants. Union locals protested that advertisements for educator (peer support) excluded diploma-holding educators and eroded wage grids. The transition toward professional status was therefore in-between—legal enough for hiring, too ambiguous for closure.

Phase 4: Fragmentation of communitas (2015–2024). A leadership split in 2015 shattered the Rehab-Advocates partnership. While Advocates lobbied the Ministry to take over the Peer Network, a Montréal faction—later Mentors, affiliated with Université de Montréal—launched a rival year-long, credit-bearing programme. The coexistence of two credentials divided peer support workers along regional and ideological lines. To simplify administration, the Ministry authorized direct hiring under the generic title *educator* and delegated wage bargaining to local unions. Some unions negotiated side letters; others resisted, creating pay gaps of roughly 20 percent. A 2019 arbitration upheld employers' right to require Peer Network certification, yet the deeper jurisdictional vacuum remained. By 2024 most peer support workers were on hospital payrolls, but the continued absence of a protected title, a standardized curriculum, and a province-wide association left their professional status precarious and undefined.

At this point, the exclusive knowledge of mental health recovery gained by peer support workers through lived experience is now well recognized by the professional sector, but the relative weakness and heterogeneity of the credentialing programs that certify their expertise may not help their efforts to obtain a dedicated job title from Ministry. Nonetheless, the ongoing drift towards employment sites hiring peer support workers directly as ‘educators’ is a relative progression in their effort to establish a work jurisdiction within the professional domain of mental health care.

DISCUSSION

In this paper, we studied peer support workers in mental health care, showing how their professionalization project unfolds in the zone in-between the community and professional sectors over a period spanning decades. This phenomenon has important implications for those who pursue such projects, and for stakeholders in the professional domains where these projects unfold. In this discussion, we intend to develop a process model of liminality in professionalization projects, and explore how this phenomenon applies to empirical settings beyond the one we have studied. Drawing on organizational studies of liminality (Horvath et al., 2015; Söderlund & Borg, 2018) and professional work (Anteby et al., 2016; Langley et al., 2019), we will articulate the theoretical contributions of our study around the themes of *communitas*, in-betweenness, and transition. Below, we outline our key contributions to understanding professionalization with this lens.

Communitas

The idea of *communitas* helps to make sense of group dynamics involving solidarity among liminars engaged in a collective process of transformation (Howard-Grenville et al., 2011; Turner, 1969). We showed how, in Phase 1, the coming together of *communitas* enabled collective action for mutual aid organizing among mental health service users and community allies. This echoes other studies that have found *communitas* as enabling collective action for self-change within dedicated social spaces where normative expectations are altered (Johnson et al., 2010; Shortt, 2015; Sturdy et al., 2006). The initial coming together of *communitas* – i.e., community organizations mobilizing to organize peer-run mutual aid groups as organizational alternatives to professional services – sets the stage for events occurring later in the professionalization project of peer support workers. It represents the phase of separation that initiates rites of passage in Van Gennep's (1909) foundational theorization of liminality.

Our study suggests transition periods can extend for decades and become established in interstitial spaces of the institutional structure, potentially never reaching the end point aspired to by liminars. Phase 4 in our findings illustrates how the fragmentation of *communitas* might hinder the progression of a professionalization project by undermining the ability of those who pursue it to self-govern and represent their interests cohesively in the professional sector. This interpretation resonates with other studies finding that *communitas* can be fleeting and fragmented (Shortt, 2015; Whyte et al., 2023), causing liminars to experience moral ambiguity and disorientation (Douglas, 1966; Toraldo et al., 2019).

In-betweenness

Social positions and roles in-between different groups offer opportunities for creativity and learning (Ryan, 2019; Swan et al., 2016), but they also imply tensions, uncertainties, and moral ambiguity (Cunha & Cabral-Cardoso, 2006; Frey, 2022). Our findings about the professionalization project of peer support workers resonate with studies that have viewed paid care as a liminal activity straddling the ambiguous zone in-between voluntary care as part of community relations and paid care as a professional service (Ladge et al., 2012; Zadoroznyj, 2009). Peer support workers are “matter out of place” (Douglas, 1966, p. 36) playing a role that does not fit neatly within either the community or professional (Turner, 1969, p. 109) – they are

stuck in the zone in-between. Our findings also hint at the tension between the different normative expectations of community peers and professional colleagues, which has been noted in other recent studies (Golden & Bencherki, 2024; Mavin & Yusupova, 2024). This tension between the normative expectations of work versus nonwork has also been noted in various organizational studies of professionalization projects (Hochschild, 2013; Nelsen & Barley, 1997; Zilber, 2002), with which our research resonates.

We have on hand rich interview data with peer support workers on their lived experience of liminality at work, that we intend to analyze further as we develop this manuscript. This will help complement our study's findings, so far mostly focused on historical dynamics, with an analysis of the lived experience of peer support workers pursuing this professionalization project. The ambiguity and stigma experienced by workers in liminal roles or positions, who belong and not belonging to the organization at the same time, is very present in our data and it echoes recent studies of liminality at work (Frey, 2022; Nash, 2024). A multilevel analysis that combines historical and experiential views promises to uncover richer theoretical insights into liminality in professional work.

Transition

Van Gennep's (1909) foundational theorization of the phases of separation, liminality, and incorporation in rites of passage has inspired voluminous research on periods and processes of transition in professional work and organizational life. Underpinning this initial formulation of liminality theory, there is the teleological idea that things are bound to happen – i.e., that the transition will reach its end point sooner or later. Our study offers a striking example of transition that remains stuck in a zone in-between the starting point (i.e., the community sector) and the presumed end point (i.e., the professional sector) of the professionalization project. It suggests that transition can become a precarious yet permanent position in the institutional structure, echoing recent studies finding that transitions in- can involve extended

Indeed, stakeholders from the professional sector are partially opening up a work jurisdiction to peer support workers because of their ability to straddle the zone in-between the community and professional sectors. Their quality as “matter out of place” (Douglas, 1966) is what makes peer support workers useful to professional-sector stakeholders and justifies the presence of the former amongst the latter. These interpretations align with recent studies showing that, while initially conceived as temporary (Turner, 1969; Van Gennep, 1909), processes of transition can extend over time and may become perpetual (Ybema et al., 2011), leading to the production of “liminal careers” characterized by institutionalized precariousness (Budtz-Jørgensen et al., 2019), where liminars evolve in a context that blurs the worlds of work and nonwork while lacking workplace protections, collective benefits, and status recognition.

REFERENCES AVAILABLE FROM THE AUTHORS